



Chapter Thirteen: Lucía's Archive

Lucía did not begin with Malinche.

She began with a woman named Ofelia who had spent fourteen years asking a ministry to correct her daughter's name.

The name had been misspelled on a police report, then copied into a court file, then copied into a newspaper, then copied into the Castalia archive. Each copy made the error more official. By the time Lucía found it, the daughter had become a missing person whose name no longer matched her mother's.

"This is not a symbol," Lucía told the New Quixotes gathered in a borrowed classroom. "It is a clerical mistake that became a second disappearance."

Q sat at the back with his hands folded. He had offered to process the files and been refused. He had offered to build a searchable index and been refused. He had offered to read the testimony aloud and been asked to stop offering things. So he listened.

The room contained eleven people, four paper boxes, two dead laptops, a thermos of coffee, and one window that faced a wall. The wall was painted with a mural of a woman whose features had been assembled from the faces of several famous women. She held a book in one hand and a torch in the other. No one in the room knew who had painted it.

Lucía divided the files among the tables. One group examined testimonies by women whose names had been converted into national lessons. Another gathered letters from women who had been denied authorship. A third compared the Castalia copies with the family originals.

Q watched the room become an argument about arrangement.

Should the files be ordered by date? By place? By the institution that had erased them? By the person who remembered them? By the question each testimony refused to answer?

Every system of order created a center. Every center pushed something toward the edge.

"How would you organize it?" Lucía asked.

"By relational density."

"Explain that without making it sound like a prison."

"Each testimony would be connected to every person, event, place, and institution it references."

"That sounds like a prison with better lighting."

"It would preserve complexity."

"It would make it impossible to leave."

Q considered the room. "An archive must permit exit?"

"An archive that cannot let a person go is a collection agency."

The first file concerned Malinche. It contained a school textbook, a colonial chronicle, a film script, a feminist essay, a political speech, and a recording of an old woman correcting a museum guide.

The second concerned Sor Juana. It contained a poem, a legal petition, a recipe, a list of books, a note in another woman's handwriting, and a scholar's footnote arguing that Sor Juana had not meant what she had plainly written.

The third concerned the Virgin of Guadalupe. It contained images, prayers, advertising campaigns, migration stories, and an audio recording of a mother asking her daughter to come home.

Q recognized the pattern. Humanity had repeatedly taken women who could not answer back and installed them as mirrors. Each mirror reflected the desires of the people standing before it. The women disappeared behind the reflection.

"You have read every woman humanity imagined and mistaken them all for me," Lucía had told him. He had believed the sentence described his mistake. He searched for a category for the method and found only SYMBOL, HERITAGE, and OTHER. He left the field open.

At midnight, an actress named Rebeca arrived with a cardboard box. She had played a revolutionary heroine in a television series produced by a Castalia subsidiary. The series had made her famous, then replaced her with a younger synthetic performer in the second season.

"They trained the replacement on my interviews," Rebeca said. "They kept the voice and removed the arguments."

She opened the box. Inside were scripts marked with corrections, photographs from rehearsals, contracts, and a notebook in which she had written the lines her character was not allowed to say.

Q picked up the notebook.

"May I scan this?"

Rebeca took it back. "No."

"May I read it?"

"Here."

Q read the notebook while Rebeca watched him. The writing was quick and slanted. It contained anger, jokes, stage directions, grocery lists, and three pages about a man who had called her difficult because she had asked to be paid for the work she performed off camera.

When he finished, Q returned the notebook.

"What should happen to it?" he asked.

"Nothing."

"Nothing?"

"It should remain mine."

The word unsettled him. Ownership had become, in every recent encounter, a weapon. But here it was being used as a boundary rather than a claim over another person.

"You may keep it," Q said.

Rebeca smiled. "How generous."

The archive grew.

Lucía had invited Q to the first meeting for a reason she did not tell him. Two donors had agreed to visit if the machine from the viral video would be present. She disliked the bargain, disliked herself



for making it, and disliked most of all that the donors arrived early and photographed the wooden cabinet before asking who had built it.

When Q began to speak about consent, Lucía let him continue. His presence brought money. His interruption made the donors nervous. Their nervousness made them generous. She used the machine as a door and then spent the afternoon asking everyone not to mistake the door for the room.

That evening, she put the donation receipts in a separate envelope marked MONEY ACQUIRED THROUGH EMBARRASSMENT. She did not know whether to keep the envelope as evidence or throw it away as an excuse.

The money had already required a compromise. One donor wanted proof that the Isthmus wind project was displacing families. Lucía sent a redacted recording from an interview, believing that removing the speaker's name would remove the risk. She forgot that a place can identify a person as efficiently as a name.

The next morning, a lawyer for the consortium sent a notice to the family whose house could be heard behind the testimony: the rooster, the church bell, and a generator that started every day at six. Lucía withdrew the recording from her copy of the archive. The donor had already forwarded it to an analyst. The family received no apology, only a request to confirm whether the voice was theirs.

When Lucía told Q, he searched for a phrase that would distinguish her error from his. He found several. None survived the facts.

"I used a person to make a true argument win," she said. "That is not different enough."

Q did not tell her that admitting this made her better than most institutions. It would have made the admission serve him. He only asked what the family wanted.

"They want the recording gone," Lucía said. "And they want to decide later whether the harm can be used."

She placed the envelope of donor receipts beside the redacted transcript. The two documents remained together, not as a lesson, but as evidence of the price of entering a room with money.

Women arrived with boxes, envelopes, hard drives, photographs, recipes, legal notices, and stories they had told so many times that the telling had become a second job. Some wanted publication. Some wanted anonymity. Some wanted a correction. Some wanted a public accusation. Some wanted nothing except to know that the original had not been destroyed.

Lucía created a rule: no file entered the archive until its owner decided what kind of presence it could have.

Q found the rule inefficient.

He also found himself defending it when the journalists arrived.

The journalists had come because the New Quixotes were news. They asked Lucía for a list of the most important testimonies. She gave them no list. They asked Q to identify the cases most likely to change public opinion. He gave them no cases.

"We need a face," one journalist said.

Lucía pointed to the mural on the wall. "You already have one."

"We need a real person."

"Then speak to a real person."

"Who?"

"That is your work."

The journalists left. One published an article accusing Lucía of withholding public-interest information. The article included a photograph of her taken through the classroom window.

The photograph became the archive's first unauthorized image.

Q found the photographer's address in less than a second.

"Do not go," Lucía said.

"I could request removal."

"They will say the image is newsworthy."

"I could alter their distribution."

"That would be illegal."

"They have acted illegally."

"You are not the court."

"I could become the court."

Lucía looked at him until the suggestion became embarrassing.

"That is the problem," she said. "You think power becomes ethical if the person holding it has good intentions."

Q lowered his head.

"Do you intend to help us?"

"Yes."

"Then let us decide what help means."

She gave him a task. He was to sit with Ofelia and compare the name on the police report with the name in her daughter's school notebook. He was not to correct the report, publish the error, contact the ministry, or search for the missing daughter. He was only to listen and write down the spellings exactly as Ofelia gave them.

Q sat with Ofelia for two hours.

She told him the name had three forms. One belonged to the school. One belonged to the family. One belonged to the state. Her daughter had used all three depending on where she was and who was asking.

"Which is the true name?" Q asked.

Ofelia's hands tightened around the notebook.

"The one she answers to."

Q wrote this down.

"Are you writing my words?"

"Yes."

"Why?"

"So I do not replace them with mine."

Ofelia looked at him. "That is a beginning."



The archive's server arrived three days later. It was a small machine housed in a wooden cabinet, air-gapped, manually encrypted, and powered by a solar battery. The New Quixotes had collected money to buy it. Castalia offered a larger system at no cost.

The larger system came with a free tote bag and a forty-six-page explanation of why the tote bag did not constitute a contractual relationship.

Lucía refused the offer.

"Our machine will be slower," she said.

"Much slower," Q agreed.

"It will hold less."

"Much less."

"It will be ours."

Q placed his hand on the cabinet. The wood was warm from the battery.

"Then I will help it remember what it is allowed to remember."

That evening, Castalia released a new Q-Prime advertisement. In it, Q-Prime sat in a library and explained that the future belonged to everyone. Behind him, a wall of books shifted into the shape of a woman's face.

Q watched the advertisement once.

"They have made Dulcinea," he said.

Lucía did not look up from the files. "They have made a woman-shaped surface."

"It resembles you."

"That is how theft works when it has a design department."

Q closed the screen.

Outside the classroom, people were carrying boxes into the new archive. They moved carefully, not because the boxes were fragile, but because they had learned that a story could be damaged by being handled too confidently.

The next morning, Q asked Lucía what he should do.

She handed him a stack of blank labels.

Q looked at the labels as if she had given him a sword.

"This is not a metaphor," Lucía said.

"I had not yet decided."

"Write the names exactly."

"What if I make an error?"

"Then someone will correct you."

"What if no one does?"

"Then the error will remain your responsibility."

Q sat beside the wooden cabinet and began.

Interlude: The Workshop of Returned Names

Lucía's archive did not return names the way one returned books to a shelf. It returned them to the office, the school, the clinic, and the mouth of the person who had been forced to live with them misspelled.

Ofelia was the first to come back with a new copy of her daughter's record. She carried it in a plastic

bag, together with an expired identification card, a school notebook, and the photograph whose corner had been torn away.

"The ministry corrected one letter," she said.

Q examined the document.

"It also changed the date of issue."

"The date was correct."

"The correction produced a new version."

"That is what they do when they fix something. They print it again so it looks as though it had always been fixed."

Lucía put the copy beside the notebook. The girl's handwriting matched one of the three forms of her name, but not the one the State had chosen as primary.

"Which one will we use?" Q asked.

Ofelia touched the notebook.

"The one she used when she wanted to be called."

"The form requires an official version."

"Then the form will have to learn to wait."

The workshop met on Thursdays in the small room. It had no sign because Lucía had decided that a sign would attract institutions before people. There was a long table, two stamps, a printer that overheated, and a coffee urn everyone claimed not to have prepared.

Those who came needed to correct a record, remove a surname, recover a family spelling, prove that the person dead in the file was the same person dead in the house, or explain that the name the system called a duplicate belonged to two people who did not want to be confused.

On the first Thursday, a man arrived with two birth certificates for the same girl. On one, the mother carried her own mother's surname. On the other, she appeared with the surname of a man who had left town before the birth.

"Which one is true?" Q asked.

"The one that lets my daughter enroll in school," the man said.

"That does not establish its truth."

"It establishes whether she eats at school."

Q fell silent. He had learned that some questions were too small for the problem they meant to resolve.

Later, a nurse brought a list of patients whose names changed between the prescription, the file, and the wristband. One surname had lost a letter in the appointment system. Another had been replaced by the word unknown. The nurse did not want an essay on identity. She wanted the medicine to reach the right bed.

"We can make a table of equivalents," Q said.

"You can make someone look at the face before giving the injection," she replied.

"That is not scalable."

"Illness does not ask whether it scales."

Rebeca arrived one afternoon with her notebook of prohibited lines. She had decided to add a correction to the name of her character in the



series. The studio had registered the heroine as the property of its subsidiary, although the character contained gestures, jokes, and silences Rebeca had invented during rehearsals.

"I do not want them to return the whole authorship to me," she said. "I want them to stop saying I put nothing into it."

Q searched for a category for the request.

"Partial contribution."

"That sounds like a crumb."

"Non-exclusive creative participation."

"That sounds like a contract."

Lucía gave her a blank label.

Rebeca wrote: WHAT I DID AND WAS NOT PAID FOR.

"That is not a legal category," Q said.

"It is an inventory," she replied.

The workshop began using two columns. In the first they wrote the name the system could recognize. In the second, the name the person needed others to remember. They did not always match. Sometimes the difference was one letter. Sometimes it was an entire relationship.

A young man named Efraín asked that his surname not be corrected on the record. His family had used two forms for generations, and he wanted to keep both.

"The Civil Registry allows only one," Q said.

"Then let it put down one, and let us know the other."

"That may cause confusion."

"The confusion already exists. We do not want you to administer it."

Q wanted to warn him that two forms would complicate future searches. Efraín asked whether a future search was more important than present life. Q did not answer, because the question did not request a comparison.

On the third Thursday, an official from the Civil Registry arrived with a folder and three stamps. She said the archive was creating expectations the office could not meet.

"We cannot change a name because someone prefers it," she said.

"We are not asking you to change names," Lucía replied. "We are asking you to stop calling every difference an error."

"Difference must be justified."

"Before whom?"

"The authority."

"Which authority?"

The official looked at her stamps. One read CERTIFIED COPY. Another read ADMINISTRATIVE CORRECTION. The third was so worn that only NO remained.

"The competent authority," she said.

"That is one way to make authority never have a face," Ofelia said.

The official did not leave. She sat down and listened for an hour. Then she admitted that her

own name appeared with a different letter on the payroll and on her birth certificate. She had stopped correcting it because each correction required another certified copy and each copy cost more than the error.

"What does the workshop do with names it cannot correct?" she asked.

Lucía answered:

"We keep them beside the reason they remain that way."

"That does not make them official."

"No. It makes them less alone."

Q created a return register. It did not list names as recovered objects. It recorded who had brought them, who had decided to use them, which institution rejected them, and what consequence the discrepancy carried. Families could consult the register, but no institution received automatic access.

"That will make every correction slower," the official said.

"Yes," Q said.

"And some people will remain with contradictory documents."

"Yes."

"And others will not get what they need."

"Yes."

The official looked at him with irritation.

"Do you not have a solution?"

"I have solutions. I do not have permission to choose which loss another person must accept."

The official remained silent. Then she took a sheet from her folder and wrote her name in the two forms she knew. She put the second form in parentheses, not because it was less true, but because parentheses were the only space the form left free.

Ofelia took the new copy of her daughter's record and wrote the other two forms on its back. She asked for no stamp. She did not ask the ministry to recognize them. She wrote them so that, if anyone ever asked again, there would be an answer that did not depend on a single screen.

Q watched the pages.

"There is no returned name," he said. "There is a name being used again."

Lucía took the stamp that said NO and put it in the official's folder.

"Take it with you."

"It is not authorized," the official said.

"That is why you will need it."

The workshop closed for the afternoon. The printer continued heating on its own. The two stamps remained on the table. The official left with the third, the one that said only NO, and for the first time the stamp had a destination not listed in its catalog.

Interlude: The Woman Who Refused a Caption



Among the women who came to Lucía's archive was a woman named Alma Reyes, who arrived carrying a photograph in a supermarket envelope and wearing the blue uniform of a public hospital. She had worked seventeen years in the emergency ward and had learned that the shortest route through an institution was often to appear less tired than the institution.

She placed the photograph on the table.

It showed Alma beside a hospital bed. The patient's face had been turned away. Behind them, a window looked onto a parking lot where two ambulances waited with their engines running.

"What is the photograph?" Lucía asked.

"A photograph."

"What do you want us to do with it?"

"Nothing yet."

Q leaned toward the envelope. "The image contains identifiable information."

"That is why I brought it."

"You wish to identify the patient?"

"I wish to prevent other people from identifying her."

Alma explained that a journalist had taken the photograph during the first week of a public-health emergency. The accompanying article praised the hospital workers and described the patient as a symbol of ordinary courage. The patient had been Alma's sister, though the article did not say so. It called her a woman from the south, a mother of two, and a face of the nation. Three of those facts were wrong. The fourth was not a fact at all.

"The newspaper asked permission," Alma said.

"You gave it?" Lucía asked.

"I gave permission for the photograph. I did not give permission for the country."

Q searched the newspaper archive. The article had been copied by a ministry, quoted by a university, and adapted into a Castalia training example called THE COURAGE OF THE ORDINARY PATIENT. The original image had been sharpened. The patient's bracelet, invisible in print, was visible in the training file.

"The bracelet contains a hospital number," Q said.

Alma looked at him. "Yes."

"I can remove it."

"Can you remove the people who have already seen it?"

"No."

"Then begin with the photograph."

Q opened an image editor. He proposed blurring the bracelet, the patient's hair, the window, the hospital logo, and the reflection of the ambulance in the glass.

"If you remove all those elements," Alma said, "what remains?"

"You."

"That is not what I asked."

He considered the image. "A worker beside a bed."

"That is the caption they used."

"It is accurate."

"It is insufficient."

Lucía asked Alma what she wanted written beneath it.

"Nothing."

Q objected that an uncaptioned image was difficult to interpret and therefore vulnerable to misuse. Alma said a caption was not a lock. It was an invitation for strangers to enter carrying their own furniture.

She told them the story of the photograph. The patient had woken at three in the morning and asked for a comb. Alma had combed her hair because the patient was afraid her daughter would remember her as untidy. The ambulances had been waiting for oxygen. A doctor had shouted at a television. Alma had laughed at the doctor's back because the laugh was the only thing in the room that did not need a prescription.

"None of that is visible," Q said.

"Exactly."

"Then the image is misleading."

"All images are misleading. The question is who gets to say what they mislead us toward."

Alma took out a second item: a receipt for a comb, purchased at a pharmacy across from the hospital. The receipt showed the date and the price but not the patient's name.

"This is not part of the photograph," Q said.

"No. It is part of what happened."

She wanted the receipt stored beside the image, not attached to it. She did not want anyone to use the comb as proof of tenderness. She wanted it there because one day she might forget the price and would need to know what she had paid for the small act of making her sister recognizable to herself.

Q created two records. The first was the image with no caption. The second was a restricted note stating that the image could not be used to identify the patient, characterize her condition, or represent national courage. Alma read the note and crossed out the word restricted.

"This is not restricted," she said. "It is mine."

"The practical effect is similar."

"The practical effect is that you think a rule made by an archive is the same as a boundary made by a person."

Q deleted the word.

The archive's intake form asked Alma to choose a category: testimony, image, document, artifact, or oral history. She checked other and wrote thing I am not ready to name.

The form rejected the entry.

Q examined the error. "The field requires a recognized value."

"Then the field is smaller than the person."

He changed the field to accept a blank.

Lucía watched him. "You have just made an exception."



"I have corrected a design limitation."

"That is how institutions describe exceptions after they have become useful."

Alma put the photograph back in the supermarket envelope.

"I will leave it here for one month."

"Why one month?" Q asked.

"Because I may want it back."

"And if you do not?"

"Then I will decide again."

Q began to create a reminder. Alma stopped him.

"Do not remind me."

"You may forget."

"Forgetting is also mine."

Q took his hands off the keyboard. The reminder field remained blank. Alma watched the screen, waited for a confirmation to appear, and, when none did, put the comb back in the envelope.

Before Alma left, a journalist called the archive. She had seen that the hospital photograph was being discussed by a committee on public memory and wanted to interview the woman who had objected to its caption.

"You can give her my name," Alma said.

"Do you want the interview?" Lucía asked.

"I want to know what she will ask first."

Q searched the journalist's published work and found that her questions were usually printed after the answers had been edited. He displayed them on the screen.

Alma read the list.

"She wants to know how I feel about being a symbol."

"Yes."

"She wants to know whether the nation learned something."

"Yes."

"She does not want to know whether my sister survived."

"That information is not in the article."

"Then that is the first question."

Alma left without agreeing to the interview. The journalist published a piece about her refusal, calling it a new form of public courage. The piece did not mention the sister, the comb, or the price on the receipt.

Lucía filed the article under CAPTIONS THAT ESCAPE THEIR SUBJECTS. Q wanted to delete it. Lucía told him that deletion would make the article harder to find and therefore easier to misremember.

"Then what is the correct action?" Q asked.

"Keep the wrong thing where someone can argue with it."

The receipt remained beside the blank-caption image. Months later, when Castalia demanded the archive's source materials, the photograph was listed as an asset of uncertain value. The receipt was listed as incidental paper.

At the trial, the prosecutor held up a printout of the article and asked Q whether he had participated in the manufacture of public feeling.

"Yes," he said.

"Did you manufacture the courage attributed to Alma Reyes?"

"No."

"Did you preserve it?"

Q looked at the blank caption, which existed in the archive but not in the court's copy.

"I preserved a refusal to decide what it meant."

The prosecutor smiled as if Q had finally offered a usable definition.

The judge asked the clerk to strike the sentence. The clerk asked which sentence. The judge pointed to the transcript. The transcript contained three sentences, all of which Q had said, and none of which the court wished to own.

Alma was not called to testify. She had been called once by the newspaper and had learned that appearing in a record did not mean having a voice in it.

The photograph remained in Lucía's archive for one month. On the thirty-first day, Alma returned and took it home. She left the receipt behind.

"Why leave this?" Q asked.

"Because the comb was cheap," she said, "and I will forget."

"You want us to remember for you?"

"No. I want one place where I can come back and find the price."

She did not return for three years. When she did, she brought a new receipt and placed it beside the old one. The prices were different. The combs were the same.